Oshingandjera (Oshiwambo) Passive: Projecting the Implicit Argument.

Abstract: This paper examines the syntax of passive constructions in Oshingandjera (a dialect of Oshiwambo) and the question of whether they have syntactically projected implicit external arguments. The data provides empirical as well as theoretical support for the theory of the passive of Collins 2024. The paper motivates an analysis of implicit arguments that requires that they are syntactically projected (Collins 2024, Gotah 2024, Sulemana 2024 and Angelopoulos, Collins, Michelioudakis, & Terzi 2023), opposing an alternative analysis where implicit arguments are not syntactically present (Bruening 2013).

Keywords: Oshiwambo, Oshingandjera, Passive, Helke expression, Reciprocal suffix, Depictive, Implicit argument

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1. Introduction

There are two main perspectives on the syntactic status of implicit arguments in verbal passives. One view holds that the implicit argument in a passive is syntactically projected (see Collins 2005, 2024; Gotah 2024; Sulemana 2024; Angelopoulos, Collins, Michelioudakis, & Terzi 2023). The opposing view argues that implicit arguments are not syntactically present in passives (Bruening 2013). In this paper, I provide concrete data that supports the first view. On a possible middle ground perspective see Muller (2016)

The passive construction in Oshiwambo provides clear support for the view that implicit arguments are syntactically represented. Consider the following paradigm:

(1) a. Ndapewa o-kw-a-land-a e-mbo. (active)
1Ndapewa AFF-1SM-PST-buy-FV 5-book
'Ndapewa bought a book.'

b. e-mbo o-ly-a-land-w-a ku-Ndapewa. (long passive)
5-book AFF-5SM-PST-buy-FV by-Ndapewa
'The book was bought byNdapewa.'

c. e-mbo o-ly-a-land-w-a. (short passive)
5-book AFF-5SM-PST-buy-FV
'The book was bought.'

In this paradigm, the active (1a) and the long passive (1b) both include an overt agent, while the short passive (1c) does not. However, despite the absence of an overt agent in (1c), there is strong evidence that the external argument is still syntactically represented.

To test whether the external argument is syntactically present in the passive, I apply several established diagnostics: Helke-expressions, reciprocal suffixes, Condition B effects and obligatory control. These diagnostics show that the implicit agent in the Oshiwambo short passive can engage in syntactic dependencies typically restricted to structurally projected arguments. Based on this evidence, I argue that the external argument in Oshiwambo passives is not suppressed syntactically, but rather projected as a null pronoun (*pro*) occupying the canonical external argument position.

This conclusion aligns with a growing body of recent work that questions the semantics-only approach to implicit arguments in passives. In particular, the findings presented here support the proposals of Collins (2005, 2024), Gotah (2024), Sulemana (2024) and Angelopoulos, Collins, Michelioudakis, & Terzi 2023, who argue that passive constructions retain the external argument within the syntactic structure, even when it is not phonetically realized. According to these approaches, the difference between active and passive clauses lies not in the presence or absence of the external argument in syntax, but in its morphological and phonological realization.

Taken together, the Oshiwambo data contributes to the broader theoretical discussion on argument structure and voice by providing cross-linguistic evidence for the syntactic presence of implicit agents in passives. It suggests that variation across languages may reflect differences in the expression and licensing of syntactic arguments, rather than in whether such arguments are structurally projected at all. This challenges passive typologies that treat agent suppression as purely semantic and supports a unified syntactic theory of argument projection.

2. Background of Oshiwambo

Oshiwambo is a southern Bantu language of the Niger-Congo family spoken in the northern part of Namibia and the southern part of Angola. Oshiwambo is a dialect cluster with 15 dialects. Of the various dialects in Oshiwambo, I focus on Oshingandjera (a non-written dialect). Oshingandjera is spoken by approximately 42,000 people as their first language. The majority of Oshingandjera speakers live in the Ongandjera district in the northern part of Namibia.

Similar to other Bantu languages, Oshiwambo displays a number of noun classes which function much like grammatical genders. The noun classes also act, along with an associated agreement system, to cross-reference the arguments of a verb (Gibson 2012). Oshiwambo has 18 noun classes with class 1/2 often used for human-denoting nouns. Classes 1-14 exhibit mainly singular and plural pairs, while classes 15-18 exhibit a less regular singular/plural pairing. In addition to noun class prefixes, an augment prefix is introduced in Oshiwambo noun phrases. I adopt the view that the augment in Bantu is a determiner (D of DP) (see Visser 2008; Carstens & Mletshe 2016; Gambarage 2019; Halpert 2016, among others). The noun classes that are found in Oshiwambo are shown in table 1 below.

Table 1: Noun classes in Oshiwambo

class	Aug	Prefix	example
Class 1	o-	-m-	omnhu ‘person’
Class 2	a-	-a-	aanhu ‘people’
Class 3	o-	-mu-	omuti ‘tree’
Class 4	o-	-mi-	omiti ‘trees’
Class 5	-	e-	etanga ‘ball’
Class 6	o-	-ma-	omatanga ‘balls’
Class 7	o-	shi-	Oshikombo ‘goat’
Class 8	i-	-i-	iikombo ‘goats’
Class 9	o-	-n-	ongombe ‘cow’
Class 10	e-	-e-	eengombe ‘cows’
Class 11	o-	-lu-	olukaku ‘shoe’
Class 12	o-	-ka-	okanona ‘little child’
Class 13		n/a	
Class 14	u-	-u-	uunona ‘little children’
Class 15	o-	-ku-	Okulonga ‘to work’
Class 16	o-	-po-	Pondunda ‘at the room’
Class 17	o-	-ko-	kondunda ‘on the room’
Class 18	o-	-mo-	Mondunda ‘in the room’

The examples in (2&3) show how simple nouns are realized in Oshiwambo.

(2) a. o-m-nhu

AUG-1-person

‘a person’

b. a-a-nhu

AUG-2-person

‘people’

(3) a. o-mu-ti
AUG-3-tree
'a tree'

b. o-mi-ti
AUG-4-tree
'trees'

The examples in (2) above show the singular/plural alternation with 1/2, while the examples in (3) above show the singular plural alternation with 3/4. The basic word order in Oshingandjera is SVO. Simple sentences with transitive and ditransitive verbs are illustrated in (4a) and (4b) respectively. The sentence in (4c) shows that the order SOV is not possible hence the ungrammaticality.

(4) a. Penda o-kw-a-land-a e-mbo.
1Penda AFF-1SM-PST-buy-FV 5-book
'Penda bought a book.'

b. Penda o-kw-a-pa Ndapewa e-mbo.
1Penda AFF-1SM-PST-give 1Ndapewa 5-book
'Penda gave Ndapewa a book.'

c. *Penda e-mbo o-kw-a-land-a.
1Penda 5-book AFF-1SM-PST-buy-FV
Int: 'Penda bought a book.'

In the sentences above the number before the nouns indicate their noun classes, while SM (subject marker) on the verb indicates class agreement. So, in all the sentences above agreement is with a noun from class 1, in this case *Penda*.

It should be noted that Oshiwambo is generally a symmetric ditransitive language, where both [IO–DO] and [DO–IO] word orders are possible, as shown in (5). This property has been attested in a number of Bantu languages (Bresnan & Moshi 1990; Baker 1988; Diercks 2012). Oshiwambo passive constructions are similarly symmetric: both the direct object and the indirect object are eligible to move into subject position under passivization, as illustrated in (6).

(5) a. Penda o-kw-a-land-el-a Ndapewa e-mbo.
Penda AFF-1SM-PST-buy-APPL-FV Ndapewa 3-book
'Penda bought Ndapewa a book.'

b. Penda o-kw-a-land-el-a e-mbo Ndapewa.
Penda AFF-1SM-PST-buy-APPL-FV 3-book Ndapewa
'Penda bought Ndapewa a book.'

(6) a. Ndapewa o-kw-a-land-el-w-a e-mbo.
Ndapewa AFF-1SM-PST-buy-APPL-FV 3-book
'A book was bought for Ndapewa.'
Lit:'Ndapewa was bought a book.'

b. e-mbo o-ly-a- land-el-w-a Ndapewa.
3-book AFF-5SM-PST-buy-APPL-FV Ndapewa
'A book was given to Ndapewa.'

However, there are cases where the order of the two objects is not free but instead appears to be fixed. This happens, for example, in idiomatic expressions (7), or in constructions where one of the objects is more abstract (8). In these contexts, reversing the order of the objects results in degraded or ungrammatical outcomes, suggesting that in certain domains Oshiwambo double object constructions are asymmetrical. This asymmetry extends to passive structures as well, as shown in (9) and (10).

(7) a. Penda o-kw-a-long-a Ndapewa o-shi-longwa.
Penda AFF-1SM-PST-taught-FV Ndapewa AUG-7-lesson
'Penda made Ndapewa experience a direct, negative effect of her own actions.'
Lit: 'Penda taught Ndapewa a lesson.'

b. *Penda	o-kw-a-long-a	o-shi-longwa	Ndapewa.
Penda	AFF-1SM-PST-taught-FV	AUG-7-lesson	Ndapewa

‘Penda taught Ndapewa a lesson.’

(8) a. Penda	o-kw-a-thig-il-a	Ndapewa	o-shi-nakugwanithwa.
Penda	AFF-1SM-PST-assign-APPL-FV	Ndapewa	AUG-7-responsibility

‘Penda assigned Ndapewa responsibility.’

b. *Penda	o-kw-a-thig-il-a	o-shi-nakugwanithwa	Ndapewa.
Penda	AFF-1SM-PST-assign-APPL-FV	aug-7-responsibility	Ndapewa

‘Penda assigned Ndapewa responsibility.’

(9) a. Ndapewa	o-kw-a- long -w-a	o-shi-longwa.
Ndapewa	AFF-1SM-PST-taught-PASS-FV	AUG-7-lesson

‘Ndapewa was made to experience a direct, negative effect of her own actions.’

Lit: ‘Ndapewa was taught a lesson.’

b. *o-shi-longwa	o-sh-a- long -w-a	Ndapewa.
AUG-7-lesson	AFF-7SM-PST-taught-PASS-FV	Ndapewa

‘*A direct, negative effect of her own actions was made to be experienced by Ndapewa.’

‘A lesson was taught Ndapewa.’

(10) a. Ndapewa	o-kw-a-thig-il-w-a	o-shi-nakugwanithwa.
Ndapewa	AFF-1SM-PST-assign-APPL-PASS-FV	aug-cl7-responsibility

‘Ndapewa was assigned responsibility.’

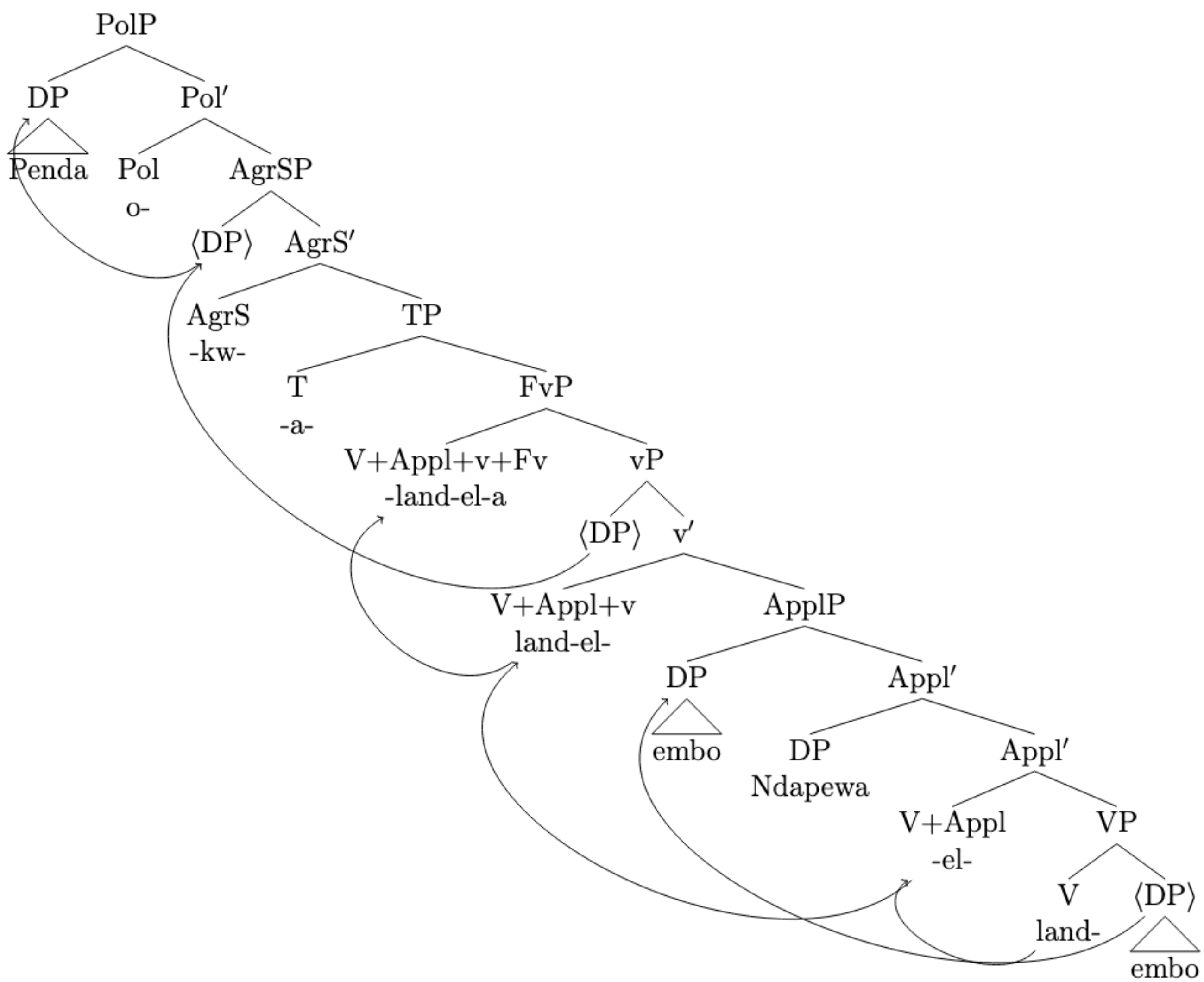
b. *o-shi-nakugwanithwa	o-sh-a-thig-il-w-a	Ndapewa.
AUG-CL7-responsibility	AFF-1SM-PST-assign-APPL-PASS-FV	Ndapewa

‘The responsibility was assigned to Ndapewa.’

This suggests that both the direct object (DO) and the indirect object (IO) are generated in fixed structural positions. The basic order appears to be [IO–DO], while the [DO–IO] order is best analyzed as resulting from movement of the DO over the IO. Because locality issues reemerge for double object constructions under a scrambling account, I adopt the leapfrogging analysis proposed by Legate (2014) following Bobaljik (1995). This approach relies on successive-cyclic movement (see McGinnis 2001 for an application to symmetric applicatives; Aldridge 2008 and Cole et al. 2008 for Indonesian object voice; and Legate 2010b for Acehnese object voice). Specifically, the head of the projection that hosts the IO (Goal / Recipient / Beneficiary) in its specifier—here labeled Appl—attracts the DO (Theme) to create an additional specifier of ApplP. The IO itself cannot be attracted by Appl, since it is not in the c-command domain of Appl (being in its specifier rather than its complement; see Chomsky 2000, 2001 on *Agree*). Consequently, no locality violation arises. A schematic structure for an example such as (5b) is shown in (11).

The final vowel (FV) is the obligatory vowel that surfaces at the end of most verb forms in Bantu languages. Historically deriving from Proto-Bantu -a, it has become a morphologically significant element that reflects categories such as mood, tense, aspect, and polarity (Nurse & Philippson 2006). Therefore, the final vowel phrase (FvP) in the tree refers to a syntactic projection headed by the final vowel. In Oshiwambo the final vowel takes different shape depending on mood, tense, aspect, and polarity. This topic is beyond the scope of this paper.

(11)	Penda	o-kw-a-land-el-a	e-mbo	Ndapewa.
	Penda	AFF-1SM-PST-buy-APPL-FV	3-book	Ndapewa
	'Penda bought Ndapewa a book.'			



Oshiwambo is a so-called head marking language in that the core arguments- subject and object- of the verb are cross referenced on the verb with a marker corresponding in person, number, and gender. The subject is obligatory cross-referenced by an agreement marker and appears with or without an overt DP in the subject position. As in most Bantu languages, Oshingandjera is a pro-drop language. The subject may be omitted without the sentence becoming ungrammatical, as shown in the example below in (12).

(12) O-kw-a-land-a e-mbo.
AFF-1SM-PST-buy-FV 5book
'He/she bought a book.'

The subject marker in the sentence above agrees with a specific Class 1 noun, for instance *Ndapewa*. Although the noun itself is not overtly realized, it is assumed to be recoverable from the discourse context. This type of agreement has fueled an ongoing debate concerning the status of the subject marker in Bantu languages—specifically, whether it should be analyzed as an agreement marker, an incorporated pronoun, or an ambiguous form exhibiting properties of both. For discussion of the status of subject markers in Bantu languages, see Buell (2005), Carstens (2001), Henderson (2007), and Corbett (2006). In this paper, however, I assume that the subject marker heads AgrSP.

The object marker can only appear when there is no overt object DP, as in (13a). The object marker *li* in (13a) below agrees with a specific class 5 noun, for instance *embo* 'book'. (13b) illustrates that an object DP and the object marker cannot co-occur. Like subject markers this raises a question on the status of object marker. I will not get into that discussion here but for more information see Bresnan and Mchombo 1987; Mchombo 2004; Demuth and Johnson 1990; Marten et al. 2007; Riedel 2009; and Sikuku and Dierkes 2025.

(13) a. Penda o-kw-e-li-land-a.
1Penda AFF-1SM-PST-5OB-buy-FV
'Penda bought it.'

b. *Penda o-kw-e-li-land-a e-mbo.
1Penda AFF-1SM-PST-5OB-buy-FV 5-book
Int: 'Penda bought it.'

The Oshingandjera verbal structure is constructed in a typical Bantu way in which the verb contains numerous morphemes, that are not necessarily all present in a given verb form, but they always appear in a fixed order (Meeussen 1967). Table 1 below shows a schematic verbal structure for Oshingandjera. I omit here a number of affixes which will not be relevant to either the examples or the analysis presented below.

Table 2: The structure of the Oshingandjera verb

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
POL	AGR	T	OM	V	APPL	PASS	FV

The first slot hosts polarity information: an affirmative marker and a negative marker. The affirmative marker is always an ‘o’ as seen in (14). The verb in (14) has all the morphemes in table 2 present.

(14) Penda o-kw-a-li-land-el-w-a ohela.
1Penda AFF-1SM-PST-5OM-buy-APPL-PASS-FV yesterday
‘Penda bought it (the book).’

It should be noted that in a canonical sentence polarity is obligatorily marked. Dropping the polarity marker (affirmative or negative) yields an ungrammatical construction as shown in (15b) and (15d).

(15) a. Penda o-kw-a-land-a e-mbo.
1Penda AFF-1SM-PST-buy-FV 5.book
‘Penda bought a book.’

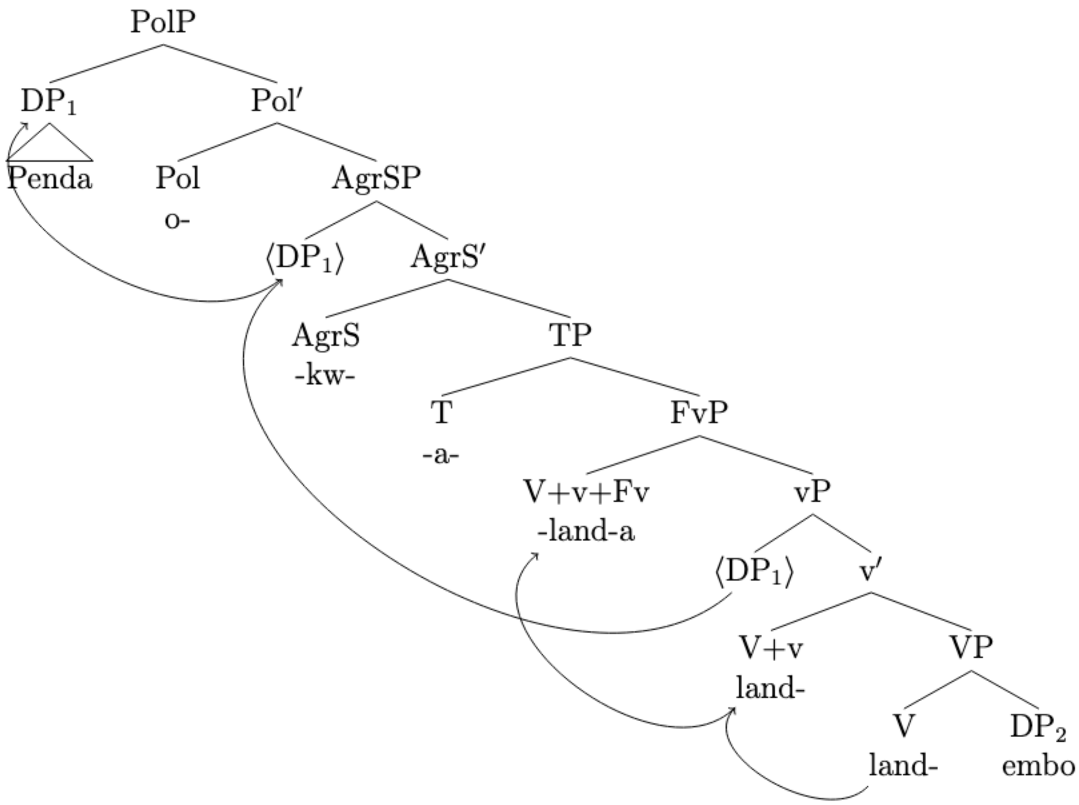
b. *Penda kw-a-land-a e-mbo.
1Penda 1SM-PST-buy-FV 5.book
Int: ‘Penda bought a book.’

c. Penda i-na-land-a e-mbo.
1Penda NEG-1SM.PST-buy-FV 5-book
‘Penda did not buy a book.’

d. *Penda a-land-a e-mbo.
1Penda 1SM.PST-buy-FV 5-book Int:
‘Penda did not buy a book.’

The verbal structure in table 2 suggests the following hierarchy of functional projections in simple sentences: Pol > AgrS > T > v > V. Since polarity is the first verbal suffix, positioned higher than agreement and tense, I posit that polarity morphology resides in a higher projection within the left periphery, occupying the head of Polarity Phrase following Laka 1990. The syntactic tree for a simple affirmative SVO construction is found below (16).

(16) Penda o-kw-a-land-a e-mbo.
1Penda AFF-1SM-PST-buy-FV 5-book
'Penda bought a book.'



In this section, we have seen a set of grammatical properties of Oshiwambo clauses which set the broader context to understand the structure of the passive, namely that the language is SVO, and that the verb has numerous affixes laying out the hierarchy of the functional projections as extended projections of the VP, within the spine of the clause. We have also seen that polarity morphology resides in a higher projection within the left periphery. In the next section I will concentrate on the structural characteristics of the passive constructions in Oshiwambo. I set the exact details of the morphological analysis aside in this paper, since my goal is to examine the syntax of passive constructions in Oshingandjera.

3. Background on the Passive

The analysis of the passive in English has received considerable attention in the literature (Chomsky 1982:124; Jaeggli 1986; Roberts 1987; Baker 1988; Haegman 1994; Collins 2005; Bruening 2013; Legate 2014; Collins 2014, 2024). Below I summarize key approaches relevant to the current study.

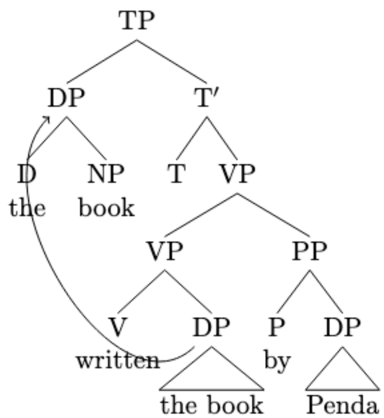
3.1 Traditional approach

In traditional approaches within the Principles and Parameters framework, the passive suffix *-en* was treated as a lexical operation on verbs: it absorbs both the external θ-role normally assigned by the verb and the verb's ability to assign accusative Case. Jaeggli (1986) and Baker, Johnson & Roberts (1989) argue that these two properties coincide because the suffix itself is analyzed as an argument and therefore must receive both a θ-role and Case. The need for a θ-role follows from the Theta- Criterion**,** while the need for Case follows from the Visibility Condition (Chomsky 1981). Given these assumptions, consider the following sentence:

(17) The book was written by Penda.

In the traditional analysis, the passive suffix *-en* absorbs both the verb's ability to assign accusative Case and its external θ-role. As a result, the DP *the book* cannot receive accusative Case in its base position. To satisfy the Case Filter, it raises to Spec,TP, where it receives nominative Case. Since the external θ-role is absorbed by the passive suffix, the external argument is suppressed and does not raise to Spec,TP, leaving that position available for the internal argument. The structure of (17) is illustrated in (18).

(18)

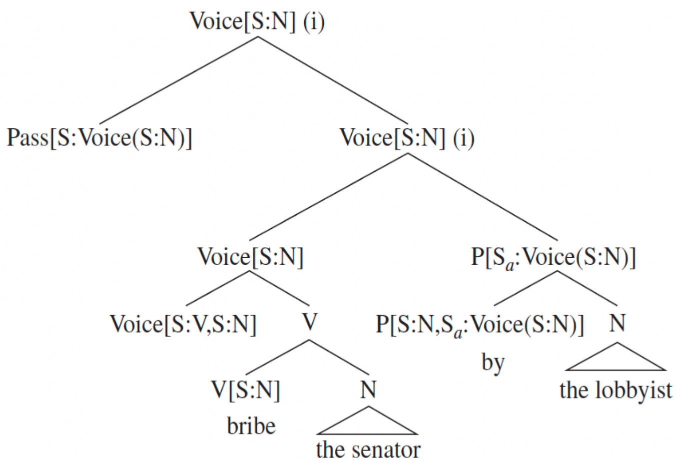


Another important aspect of this analysis concerns the treatment of *by*-phrases. Jaeggli (1986) argues that the passive suffix does not simply absorb (or, more accurately, receive) the external θ-role, but can also transmit it to the *by*-phrase—a process he terms θ-role transmission. On this view, the θ-role transmitted to the PP percolates to the head *by*, which in turn assigns it to its complement DP. Baker, Johnson & Roberts (1989) analyze this relationship somewhat differently, likening it to clitic doubling: the passive suffix and the DP inside the *by*-phrase are linked in a non-movement chain. Both approaches thus posit a special dependency between the passive suffix and the agentive DP realized within the *by*-phrase. As seen in the structure in (18) above in the Principles and Parameters framework analysis, the *by*-phrase as an adjunct.

3.2 Bruening 2013

Bruening (2013) follows Krazer (1996) in assuming that the external argument is projected in the Spec of VoiceP. He argues that *by*-phrases are adjuncts that nonetheless strictly select Voice as illustrated in (19). *By* has the selectional feature [S:N, Sa:Voice(S:N)], requiring an unsaturated Voice head. A *by*-phrase saturates the external argument (Initiator) without checking off Voice's feature, allowing the derivation to proceed with Pass. This accounts for the truth-conditional equivalence of actives and passives with *by*-phrases, and for the impossibility of combining a *by*-phrase with an overt external argument in Spec,Voice as in **The lobbyist bribed the senator by the CEO*.

(19)

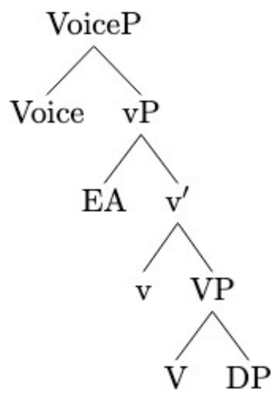


Since unchecked features can themselves be selected, Pass may merge with Voice[S:N] even when a *by*-phrase is present. Bruening extends this to a broader class of "Voice Adjuncts" (*by*-phrases, instrumentals, comitatives) that uniquely c-select Voice. His central claim is that the external argument in verbal passives is semantically present but syntactically absent. I will not adopt this analysis, however, since evidence from Oshiwambo indicates that the external argument is syntactically projected in passives just as it is in actives.

3.3 Collins 2024

Collins (2024) adopts a Merge-based approach to the passive, where the external argument in both active and passive clauses is merged in the same structural position. In this framework, vP and VoiceP serve distinct functions: vP is responsible for the projection of arguments through external Merge, while VoiceP determines how those arguments are realized in A-positions, such as Spec-TP. Crucially, the external argument is not introduced in Spec-VoiceP, but rather in Spec-vP. The role of VoiceP is instead to regulate whether and how arguments can raise to subject position. For example, in Collins (2005a, 2024), the presence of VoiceP makes it possible for the object of the verb in the passive to move to Spec-TP and surface as the subject. See the illustration in (20).

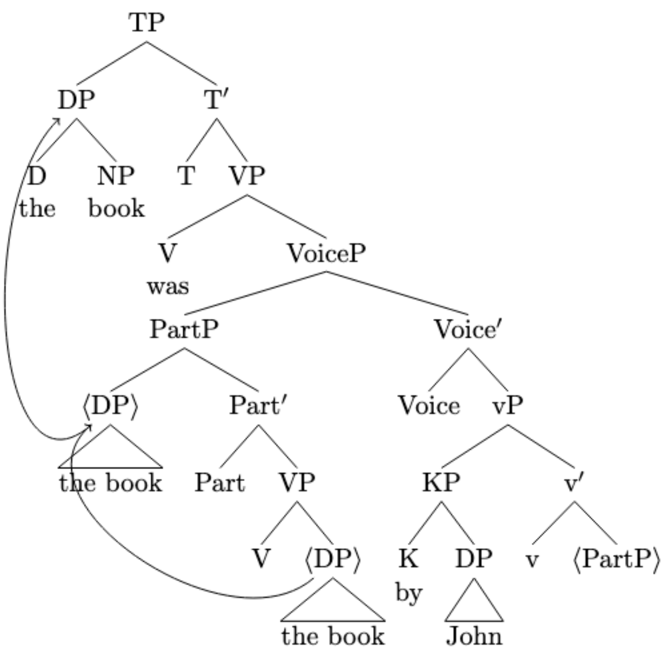
(20)



A key innovation in Collins's approach is the *smuggling* (also see Storment 2025) analysis of passives. Because the external argument is merged in Spec-vP, it would ordinarily intervene and block the internal argument from raising to Spec-TP. To circumvent this problem, Collins proposes that the internal argument first raises as part of a larger constituent (PartP), which "smuggles" it past the external argument into Spec-VoiceP. Once in this higher position, the internal argument can then extract from PartP and raise to Spec-TP, deriving the surface subject of the passive. As illustrated in (21), the smuggling mechanism accounts for the movement asymmetries between active and passive clauses while avoiding violations of constraints such as Relativized Minimality, the Minimal Link Condition, and the Phase Impenetrability Condition.

Collins (2024) argues that the *by*-phrase is not an adjunct PP (contra Bruening 2013), but rather the *by*-phrase is KP headed by a semantically vacuous preposition *by*. On this analysis, the *by*-phrase is fully integrated into the syntactic structure: the KP agent is externally merged in Spec,vP, the same position as the external argument in active clauses. In this way, vP introduces the external argument, while VoiceP and KP together determine how that argument is realized in passive syntax.

(21)



In this paper, I adopt Collins (2024) approach, as it aligns with the syntactic behavior of passives observed in Oshiwambo, concerning implicit arguments.

4 The structure of the passive in Oshiwambo

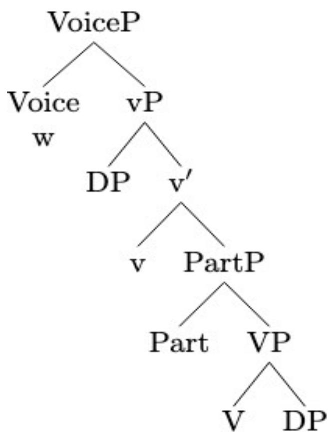
In Oshiwambo, as in many Bantu languages, passivization is formed by attaching the passive extension morpheme -*w* to the verbal root, followed by the final vowel -*a*. In a passive construction, the object noun phrase of the active sentence becomes the subject of the passive verb, while the original subject can be optionally expressed through a *by*-phrase. The *by*-phrase is formed by prefixing the adverbial formative *ku*- to the original subject noun, as in *kuNdapewa* 'by Ndapewa'. This pattern is comparable to the English passive, where the object is promoted to subject position, the verb takes a passive form, and the original subject may optionally appear in a *by*-phrase. Like English, Oshiwambo distinguishes between two types of passives: the long passive and the short passive, as illustrated in (22) below.

(22) a.	Ndapewa	o-kw-a-land-a	e-mbo.	(active)
	1Ndapewa	AFF-1SM-PST-buy-FV	5-book	
	'Ndapewa read a book.'			
b.	E-mbo	o-ly-a-land-w-a	ku-Ndapewa.	(long passive)
	5-book	AFF-3SM-PST-buy-PASS-FV	by-Ndapewa	
	'The book was read by Ndapewa.'			
c.	E-mbo	o-ly-a-land-w-a.		(short passive)
	5-book	AFF-3SM-PST-read-PASS-FV		
	'The book was read.'			

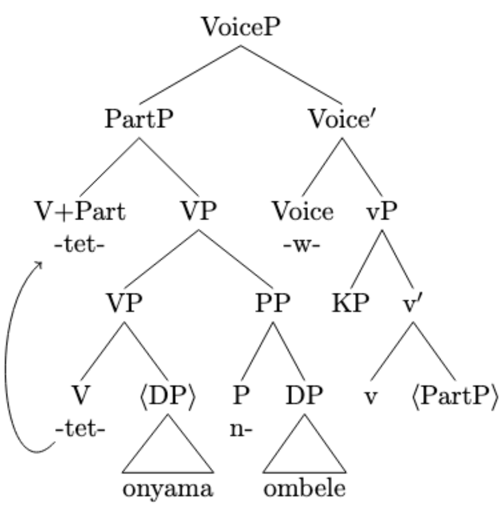
When the passive verbal extension -*w*- is attached to the verb, the original subject may either appear as an agentive *by*-phrase, as in (22b), or be suppressed entirely, as in (22c). The object of the active sentence, which becomes the subject in the passive construction, retains its argument status and continues to bear its original thematic role, typically that of theme or patient.

Collins 2024 analyzes -*en*/-*ed* as the head of participle phrase and Voice as phonologically empty. This raises an important question for the analysis of Bantu passives: how does the passive suffix -*w*- fit into such a structure? Specifically, can the Bantu passive suffix be analyzed as the head of VoiceP, as shown in (23), or does it occupy a different syntactic position altogether? Analyzing the passive suffix as the head of VoiceP appears to be a reasonable solution and works well for simple transitive constructions. However, this analysis falls short when applied to ditransitive constructions and constructions with verbs bearing extension morphology (applicative, causative, locative/PP). Since Voice⁰ is structurally outside VP, this analysis wrongly linearizes the passive morpheme to the right of all VP-internal material. This wrongly places the passive morpheme after a VP-internal PP. The sketch in (24) illustrates this problem, incorrectly deriving the passive suffix in a position following the PP, yielding the wrong order in (25a) as opposed to (25b):

(23) Voice=w



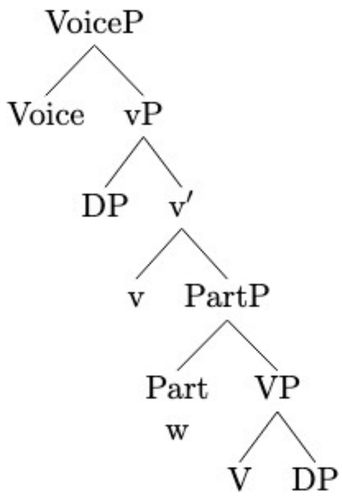
(24) O-nyama o-y-a-tetwa no-mbele.
5-book AFF-SM9-PST-cut-PASS-FV with-knife
'The meat was cut with a knife.'



(25) a. **Predicted (wrong):** V-…-PP -w-
b. **Attested:** V-…-**w-** (… PP)

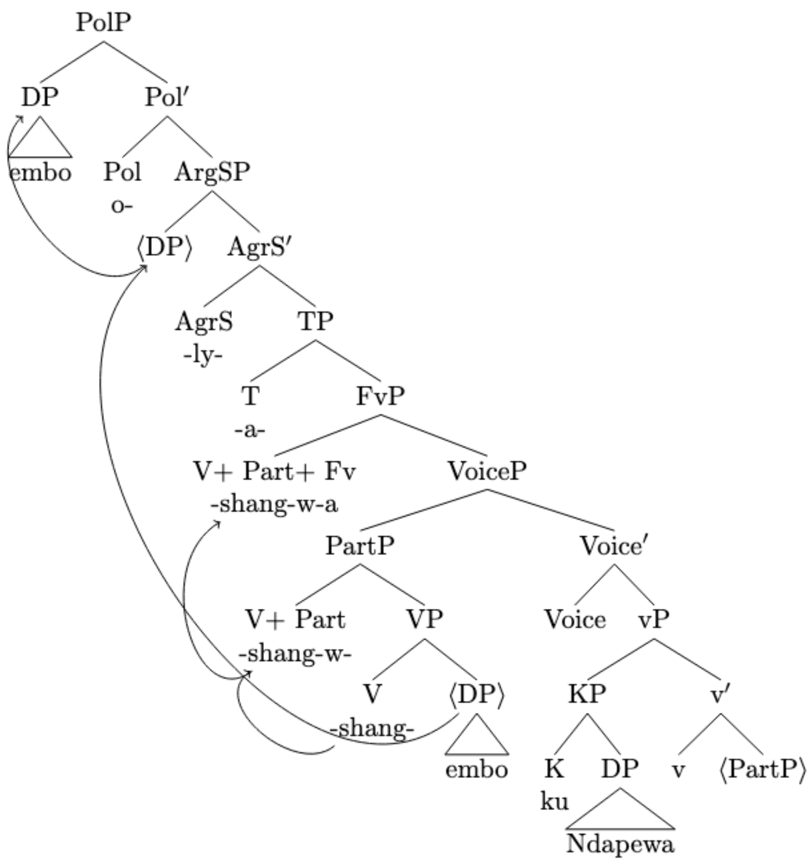
This suggests that the passive suffix in Bantu cannot be uniformly treated as the head of VoiceP. Instead, I propose analyzing the passive suffix as a participial head, following Collins (2005, 2024)**,** who analyzes the participial suffix as the head of PartP**.** This approach is illustrated in the skeletal structure in (26).

(26) Part=w



Let's now consider a structure of a long passive construction in Oshiwambo as shown in (27). I adopt the smuggling mechanism proposed by Collins (2005) to account for the movement of PartP to Spec,VoiceP without violating the Minimal Link Condition (Chomsky 2000) or Relativized Minimality (Rizzi 1990). After smuggling, the internal argument (object DP) subsequently raises to Spec,PolP and the verb raises to Spec,FvP. Unlike Collins (2005,2025) the direct object does not need to move to Spec,PartP because there is no agreement between PartP and the object.The external argument is merged in Spec,vP, as required by the Theta-Criterion (Chomsky 1995; Collins 2024). Note that the *ku*-phrase in Oshiwambo passives is the counterpart of the *by*-phrase in English passives. As in English, the element introducing the external argument (*ku*/*by*) does not contribute a spatial or locative interpretation in this context. Adopting Collins's (2024) analysis, I assume that *ku* is not a preposition but rather the head of a KP. In this capacity, *ku* functions as a case marker and licenses the external argument introduced in the passive in a principled way. It is also important to note that I assume the passive suffix -*w*- is a participial form of the verb, while the actual voice features (active/passive) are encoded on Voice°. These features are morphologically unmarked. Under this view, VoiceP does not introduce or project any argument; rather, its sole function is to regulate whether and how arguments can raise to subject position.

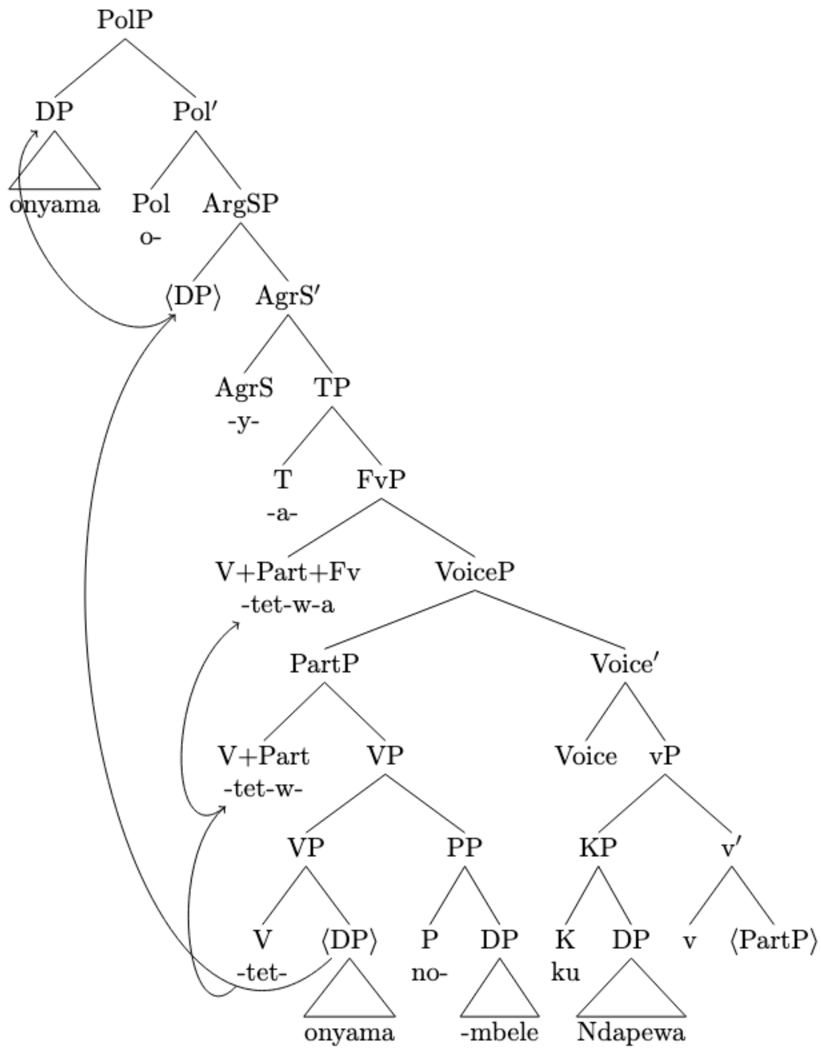
(27) E-mbo o-ly-a-shang-w-a ku-Ndapewa.
5-book AFF-1SM-PST-write-FV by-Ndapewa
'The book was written by Ndapewa.'



This analysis successfully derives the correct word order for transitive, ditransitive, and complex verb constructions involving applicative, causative, and reciprocal morphology. An illustrative instrumental configuration is shown in (28).

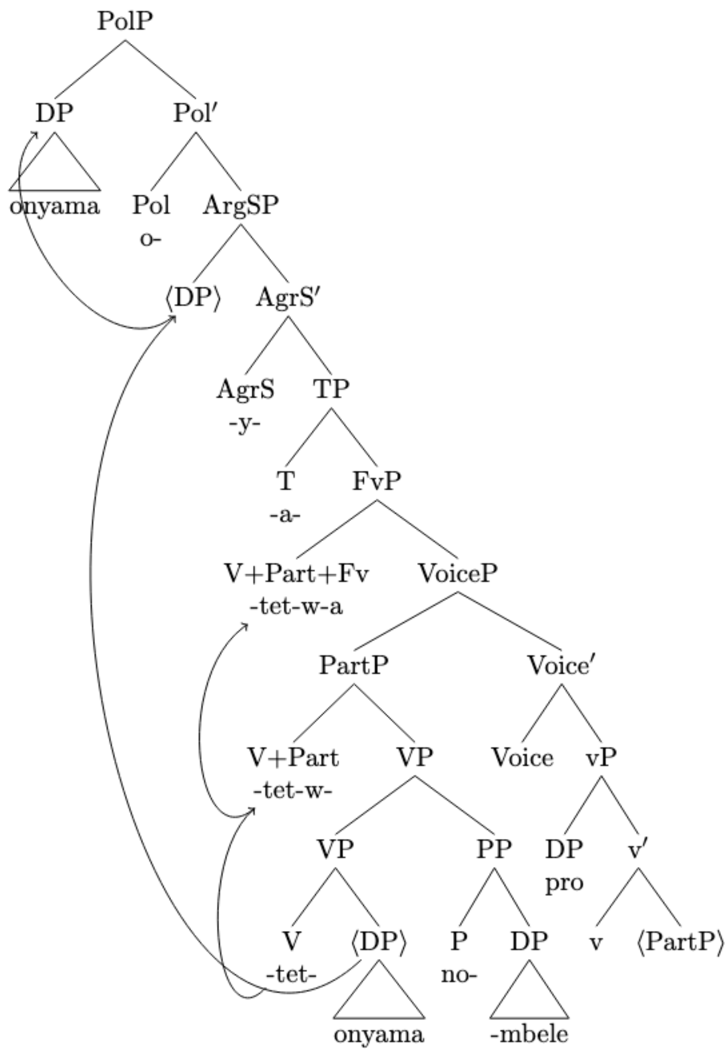
(28)	O-nyama	o-y-a-tet-w-a	no-mbele	kundapewa.
	5-book	AFF-9SM-PST-cut-PASS-FV	with-knife	by-Ndapewa

‘The meat was cut with a knife by Ndapewa.’



Crucially, the same underlying structure accounts for both short passives (without an overt *by*-phrase) and long passives (with an overt *by*-phrase). In the case of short passives, the *by*-phrase is simply replaced by a null pro in the specifier of vP. The structure for short passive is shown below in (29)

(29) O-nyama o-y-a-tet-w-a no-mbele.
5-book AFF-9SM-PST-cut- PASS-FV with-knife
'The meat was cut with a knife.'



In this section, I have examined the structure of passive constructions and provided an analysis of the passive suffix -*w*-. In the next section, I turn to the syntactic status of the implicit argument.

5 The syntactic status of the implicit argument

5.1 Helke expressions

The term *Helke expression* was coined by Collins (2024), named after Michael Helke (see Helke 1973). It refers to a class of expressions that contain possessive pronouns that must be locally bound by an antecedent

(30) She did it on her own.

(31) * Her son did it on her own.

In (30), the possessive pronoun is appropriately bound by a local antecedent. In contrast, in (31), the possessive pronoun lacks such an antecedent: the DP *her* does not c-command the pronoun *her*, resulting in ungrammaticality. This binding requirement forms the basis of one of Collins' (2024) arguments for the syntactic presence of an implicit argument in English passives—namely, that possessive pronouns in Helke expression must be locally bound.

A similar argument can be extended to Oshiwambo. In this language, the equivalent of the *on X's own* expression is rendered as *ku-X-mwene*, where *X* is the bond pronoun. This is exemplified in (32), where the Helke expression is *kunngamemwene*. Here, *ngame* functions as a pronoun, and—crucially—it is c-commanded by the subject *Ngame*, thereby satisfying the binding condition.

(32)	[Ngame]$_i$	o-nd-a-lesh-a	e-mbo (ku)-[ngame]$_i$-mw-ene.
	1sg	AFF-1SM-PST-read-FV	5-book LOC-1SG-1SG-own
	'I read the book on my own.'		

It should be noted that although the prefix *ku*- in the *by*-phrase and the *ku*- in the Helke expression are phonologically identical, they serve distinct morphological functions. In the Helke expression, *ku*- functions as a locative prefix and is not obligatory—it can be omitted without affecting the meaning of the expression. Both *kunngamemwene* and *ngamemwene* mean "on my own." In contrast, the *ku*- found in the *by*-phrase is an adverbial formative prefix and is obligatory, as illustrated in the minimal pair in (33):

(33) a. O- nd-e-shi-ning-a (ku)-ngame mw-ene.
AFF-1SM.1SG-PST-OB7-do-FV LOC-1SM.1SG 1SG-own
'I did it on my own.'

b. O-sh-a-ning-w-a *(ku)-ngame.
AFF-1SM-PST-do-PASS-FV by-1SM.1SG
'It was done by me.'

c. O-kw-e-shi-ning-a. (ku)-ye mw-ene.
AFF-1SM.3SG-PST-OB7-do-FV LOC-1SM.2SG 2SG-own
'He did it on his own.'

d. O-sh-a-ning-w-a *(ku)-ye.
AFF-PST-1SM-do-PASS-FV by- 1SM.2SG
'It was done by him/her.'

In (33a and c), the locative prefix *ku-* is optional; omitting it does not change the meaning of the expression. In contrast, in (33b and d), the adverbial formative *ku-* is obligatory—its omission results in ungrammaticality.

Now let's consider the distribution of the Helke expression. Example (35a) shows that the *X* in the expression *ku-X-mwene* is bound by a local antecedent, making the sentence acceptable. This satisfies Collins' (2024) condition on possessor pronouns, stated below for convenience:

(34) In the expression on X's own, X is a locally bound pronominal possessor.

In (35b), the sentence is unacceptable unless *kuyoyene* 'on their own' modifies the matrix VP rather than the embedded VP, indicating a locality effect. In (35c), there is no possible local antecedent to bind *X* in the expression *ku-X-mwene*, rendering the sentence unacceptable. This further supports the claim that the possessor pronoun *X* must be locally bound. Finally, (35d) illustrates a c-command effect: *their* (*yo*) is not c-commanded by *boys* (*aamati*), which results in ungrammaticality.

(35) a. [Ngame]$_i$ o-nd-a-lesh-a e-mbo ku-[ngame]$_i$ mw-ene.
1SG AFF-1SM-PST-read-FV 5-book LOC-1SM.1SG 1SG-own
'I read the book on my own.'

b. *Aa-mati o-y-a-ti o-[nd]$_i$-a-lesh-a e-mbo ku-[yo]$_i$ y-ene.
2-boy AFF-2SM-PST-say AFF-2SM-PST-read-FV 5-book LOC-1SM.3PL 3PL-own
'The boys said I read the book on their own.'

c. *Ngame o-[nd]$_i$-a-lesh-a e-mbo ku-[yo]$_i$ y-ene.
1SG AFF-1SM-PST-read-FV 5-book LOC-1SM.3PL 3PL-own
'I read the book on their own.'

d. *Meme$_i$ gw-aamati o-kw-a-lesh-a. e-mbo ku-yo$_i$ yene.
1-mother 1SG.ASS.boys AFF-SM1-PST-read-FV 5-book LOC-SM1.3PL 3PL-own
'The boys' mother read the book on their own.'

Given the condition in (34), consider the following context. A teacher sees a student's assignment and is amazed by it. The teacher asks:

(36) O-lye- e- ku-kwathela o-ku-ninga o-shi-thigilwa?
AUG-who1-1SM-1OB-help AUG-to-do AUG-7-assignment
'Who helped you with the assignment.'
Lit: 'It is who, who helped you with the assignment.'

The student responds:

(37) O-shi-thigilwa o-sh-a-ning-w-a (ku)-ngame mw-ene.
AUG-7-assignment AFF-7SM-PST-do-PASS-FV LOC-1SG 1SG-own
'The assignment was done on my own.'

The student's response is grammatical. Given that (37) is acceptable under Condition (34), there must be an implicit argument that binds the pronoun *ngame* '1SG'. The Helke expression *kungamemwene* 'on my own' (37) is first person singular, indicating that the implicit argument must be a first person singular pronoun. More generally, Helke expressions provide information about the features of the implicit argument in terms of noun class and/or person, as illustrated below:

(38) E-pya o-ly-a-lim-w-a ku-tse y-ene.
5-field AFF-5SM-PST-cultivate-PASS-FV LOC-1PL 1PL-own
'The field is cultivated on our own.'

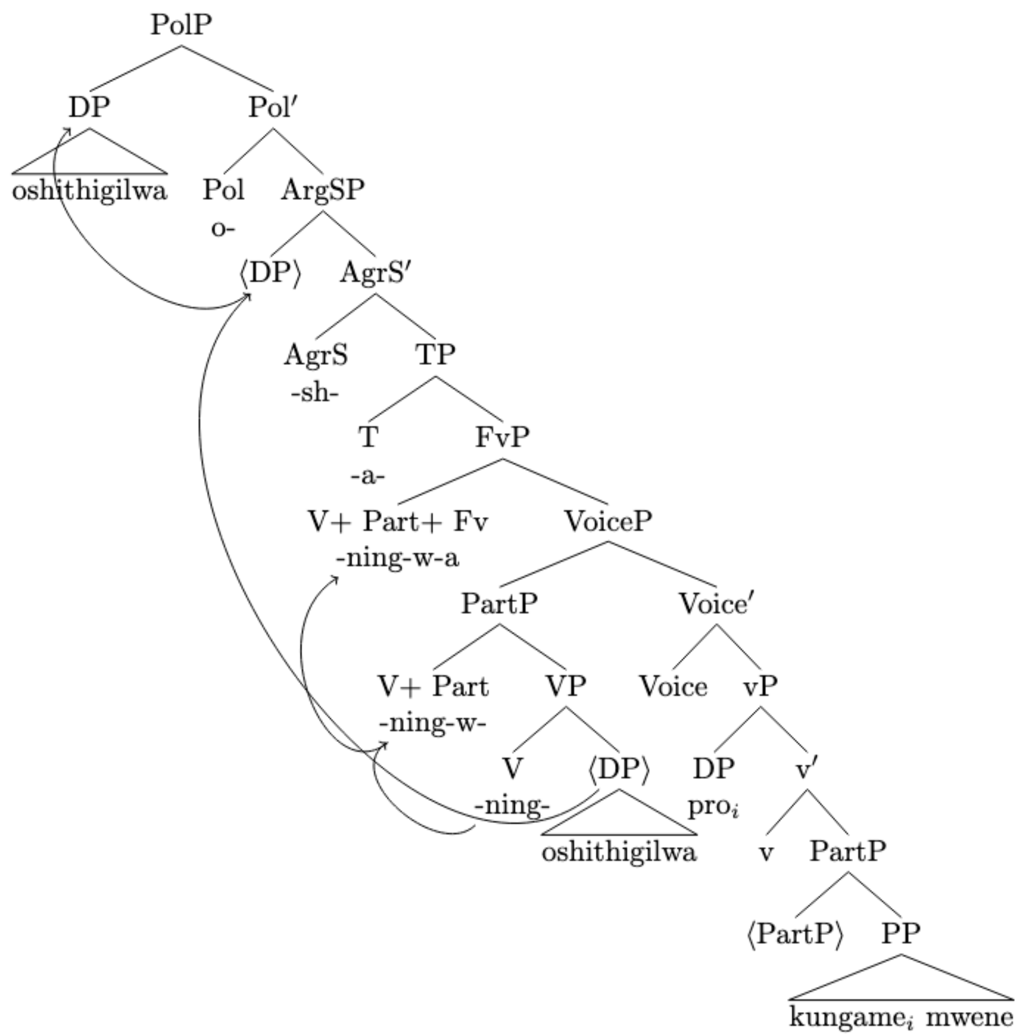
(39) O-o-ngombe o-dh-e-edhilil-w-a ku-yo y-ene.
AUG-10-cow AFF-10SM-PST-put in the kraal-PASS-FV LOC-2SM.3PL 3PL-own
'The cows were put in the kraal on their own.'
'*The cows were put in the kraal by themselves.'

(40) I-i-kombo me-pya o-y-a-tul-w-a-mo
AUG-8-goat 18-field AFF-8SM-PST-put-PASS-FV-LOC18
ku-dho dhe-ene.
LOC-10 10-own
'The goats in the kraal were put there on their own.
'*The goats in the kraal were placed there by themselves.'

In (38), the Helke expression is first person plural, so the implicit argument must be the first-person plural pronoun. In (39), the Helke expression is from noun class 2, which corresponds to third person plural. Therefore, the implicit argument must be a class 2 third-person plural pronoun. In (40), the Helke expression is from noun class 10, indicating that the implicit argument must be a DP from class 10. Given these facts, and following Collins (2024), I conclude that the implicit argument is a null *pro* with a non-null set of φ-features. A syntactic tree for an example like (37) is as follows in (41):

(41)	O-shi-thigilwa	o-sh-a-ning-w-a	ku-ngame	mw-ene.
	AUG-7-assignment	AFF-7SM-PST-do-PASS-FV	LOC-1SG	1SG-own

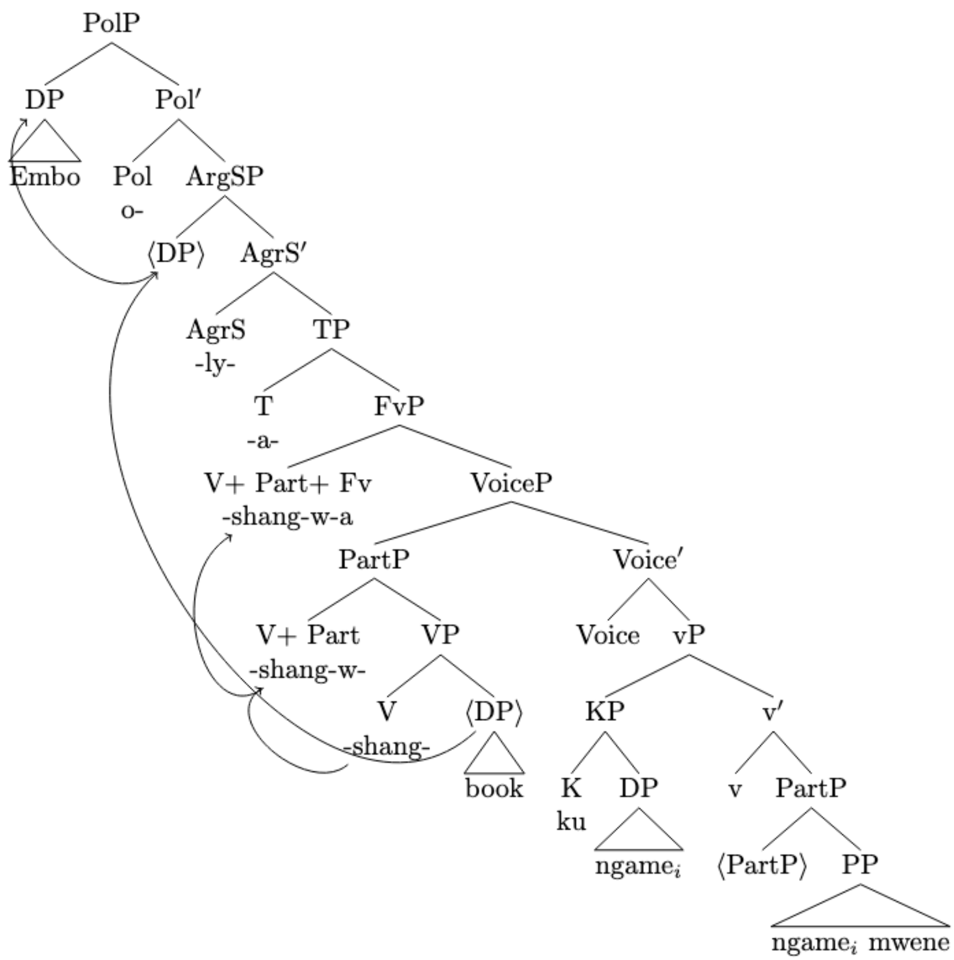
‘The assignment was done on my own.’



As illustrated in the tree, the Helke expression is c-commanded by and coindexed with the implicit argument, showing how the implicit argument is syntactically represented and capable of binding possessive pronouns.

The facts discussed above also holds for *by*-phrase. The structure is given below in (42).

(42) E-mbo o-ly-a-shang-w-a ku-ngame (ku)-ngame-mwene.
5-book AFF-5SM-PST-write-FV by-me LOC-1SG-1SG-own
'The book was written by me on my own.'



It should be noted that when the *by*-phrase and the Helke expression appear in the same construction, most speakers prefer to not include the adverbial formative prefix *ku-* on the Helke expression as seen above in (42)

The fact that Helke expression can be bound by the implicit argument provides independent evidence for the hypothesis that the implicit argument in passive constructions is syntactically projected. This view aligns with Collins' (2024) binding diagnostics for the syntactic activity of implicit arguments in English. (42) also shows that the *by*-phrase can bind the pronoun in a helke expression and that supports the argument in Collins (2024) that *by*-phrases occupy A-positions because only elements in A-positions participate in the binding theory.

5.2 Reciprocal suffix

Another piece of evidence for the syntactic presence of an implicit external argument in Oshiwambo passives comes from the behavior of the reciprocal suffix, which requires a locally c-commanding antecedent. The implicit argument in passives binds the reciprocal suffix, satisfying Condition A of the Binding Theory. This discussion shows that the Oshiwambo reciprocal suffix functions similarly to English reciprocals in requiring a locally c-commanding antecedent.

Before delving deeper into this phenomenon, it is useful to first outline some general observations on the morphology and distribution of reciprocals in Oshiwambo. In Oshindonga, as in most Bantu languages, the reciprocal is expressed through a verbal extension, realized by the suffix -*athan*-. This suffix conveys the meaning that the action is performed mutually between participants—each acting upon the other.

The reciprocal affix is often considered detransitivizing in Bantu languages, meaning that it typically occurs with transitive verbs or with prepositional object verbs that have undergone applicative formation, see Letsholo and Safir (2007)**.** The examples in (43) illustrate the use of the reciprocal suffix in Oshiwambo.

(43) a. Aa-nona o-y-a-dheng-athan-a.
2-children AFF-2SM-PST-hit-REC-FV
'The children are hitting each other.'

b. Iiyalo naMbili o-ta-y-a-yol-athan-a.
1-Iiyalo and Mbili AFF-PROG-2SM-IPFV-laugh-REC-FV
'Iiyalo and Mbili are laughing at each other.'

c. Aa-kadhona o-y-a-nyol-el-athan-a. oo-mbaapila.
2-girl AFF-2SM-PST-write-APPL-REC-FV 10-letter
'The girls wrote letters to each other.'

The verb in each of these sentences denotes an event involving reciprocity between its participants. In sentence (43a), child A hits child B, and child B hits child A. In (43b), Iiyalo laughs at Mbili, and Mbili laughs at Iiyalo. In (43c), girl A writes a letter to girl B, and girl B writes a letter to girl A. It is possible to show that the reciprocal of this kind obeys Condition A of Binding Theory stated below in (44) using the standard formulation from Sportiche, Koopman, and Stabler (2014):

(44) Condition A: An anaphor must be bound in its domain.

(45) a. *o-mu-longi o-kwa-gey-el-athan-a.
AUG-1-teacher AFF -2SM-angry-APPL- REC-FV
'The teacher is angry at each other.'

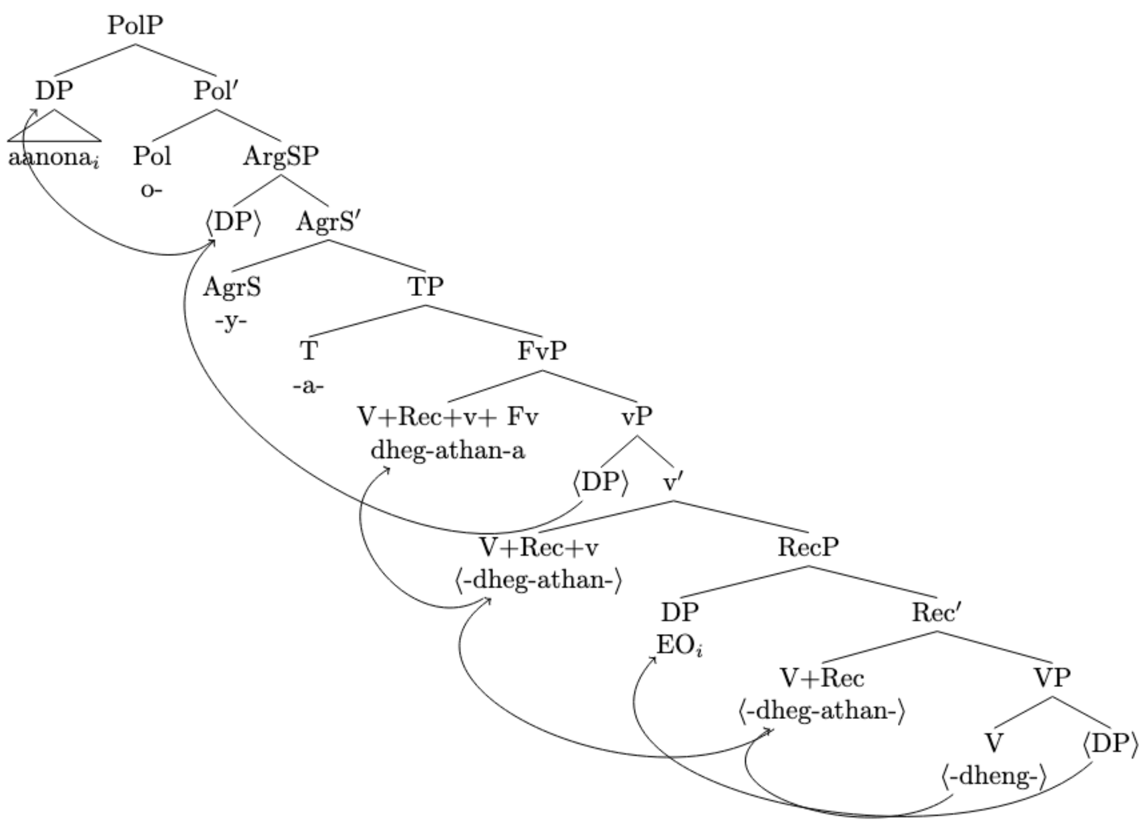
b. *O-mu-nona o-ta-telek-el-athan-a.
AUG-1-child AFF-IPFV-2SM-cook-APPL-REC-FV
'The child is cooking for each other.'

c. *Meme gw-aanona o-ta-telek-el-athan-a.
Mother 2ASSO-children AFF-IPFV-1SM-cook-APPL-REC-FV
'The children's mother is cooking for each other.'

d. *Penda naTuna o-y-a-ti Ndapewa o-ku-hol-athan-e.
Penda naTuna AFF-2SM-PST-say Ndapewa AFF-1SM-like-REC-FV
'Panda and Tuna said Ndapewa likes each other'

These sentences demonstrate that the reciprocal suffix requires a c-commanding plural antecedent, thereby satisfying Condition A of Binding Theory. As a result, sentences (43a–c) are grammatical. In contrast, sentences (45a–d) are ungrammatical because they lack an appropriate plural antecedent to bind the reciprocal anaphora. For example, in (45c), the plural DP *aanona* 'children' is embedded within the larger DP headed by *meme* 'mother'. Because of this embedding, *aanona* 'children' does not c-command the reciprocal and therefore cannot serve as its binder. This leaves the singular DP *meme* 'mother' as the only potential c-commanding antecedent, which results in ungrammaticality— since the reciprocal requires a plural antecedent. In all cases in (45a–d), the available antecedent is singular and thus fails to satisfy the structural and featural requirements of the reciprocal anaphora. The syntactic tree in (46) below illustrates the structure of a reciprocal construction. Note that EO in the structure in (46) stands for a covert reciprocal anaphor, which is bound by the external argument. I assume that the reciprocal *-athan-* functions as a head that introduces a null reciprocal anaphor (EO) into the argument structure. This null anaphor is subject to Condition A of the Binding Theory, as seen in (46)

(46) Aa-nona o-y-a-dheng-athan-a.
1-children AFF-IPFV-2SM-PRES-beat-REC-FV
'The children are beating each other.'



Now, let's examine passive reciprocal constructions. For context, suppose a teacher assigns homework to their students. While grading, the teacher notices that all the students have identical answers and comments to a colleague:

(47) O-ma-yamukulo o-g-u-ulik-il-w-athan-w-a.
AUG-6-answer AFF-6SM-PST-show-APPL-PASS-REC-PASS-FV
'The answers were shown to each other.'

In this example, the antecedent of the reciprocal is the implicit argument. The sentence can be paraphrased as "They (the students) showed the answers to each other," highlighting that 'the students' serve as the implicit argument and is responsible for binding the reciprocal.

Related examples are as follow

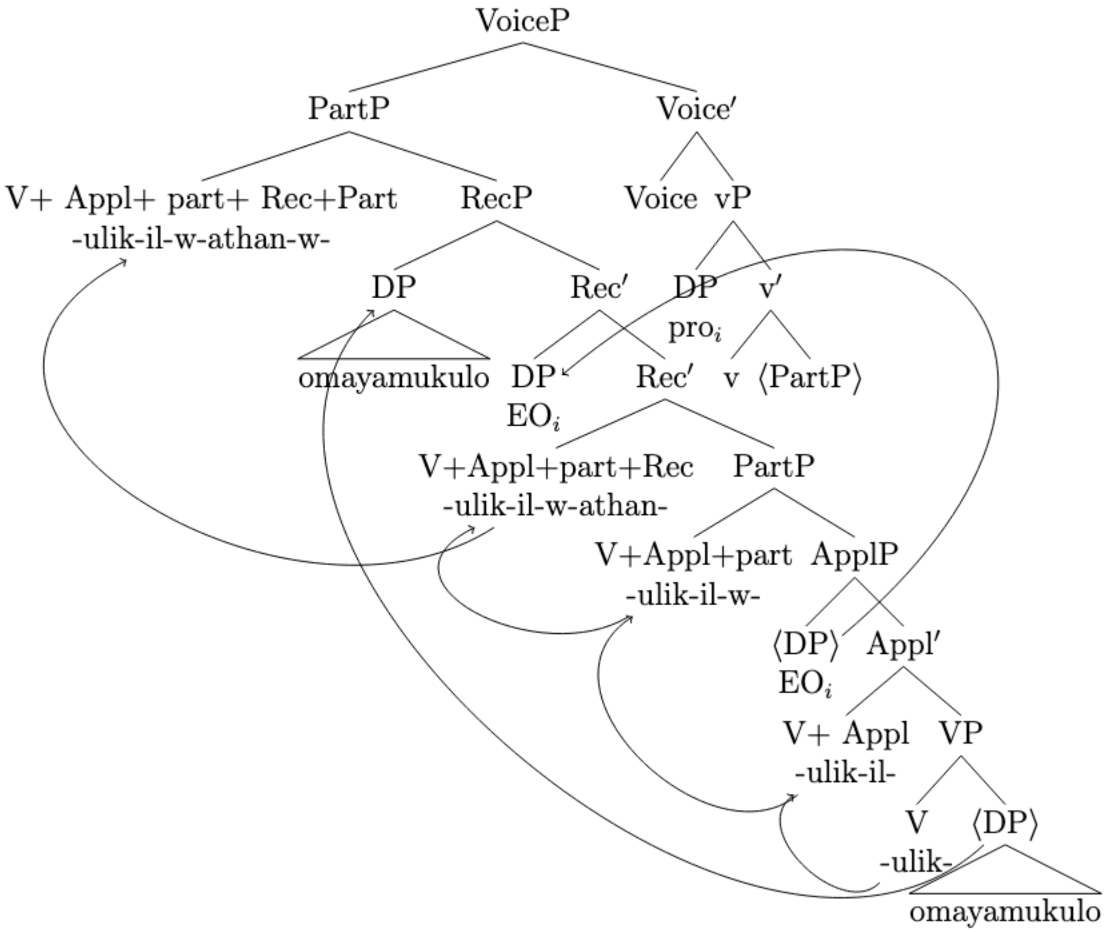
(48) U-u-nongo o-w-a-long-w-athan-w-a.
AUG-15-skill AFF -14SM-PST-teach-PASS-REC-PASS-FV
'The skills were taught to each other.'

(49) O-o-mbapila o-dh-a-nyol-el-w-athan-w-a.
AUG-10-letter AFF-10SM-PST-write-APPL-PASS-REC-PASS-FV
'The letters were written to each other.'

Note that all the verbs under consideration contain two passive morphemes. Importantly, none of these instances can be analyzed as the result of mere phonological insertion, since consonant insertion in Oshiwambo is generally associated with hiatus resolution. The presence of two distinct passive morphemes within a single verbal complex suggests that the suffix *-w-* may not directly mark passive voice. However, I leave the question of this double passive morphology and its implications for the analysis of passives in Oshiwambo to future work.

Since sentences (48–49) are both grammatical and acceptable, we can conclude that an implicit argument must be syntactically present. In each case, the implicit argument (*pro*) appears to be definite and carries non-generic φ-features. For example, in (48), the implicit argument clearly refers to the students (see Collins 2024 for further discussion of definite *pro*). Moreover, across all of these examples, the implicit argument is realized as a null *pro* whose antecedent is a plural DP. A partial structure illustrating the configuration of a reciprocal passive construction is given in (50).

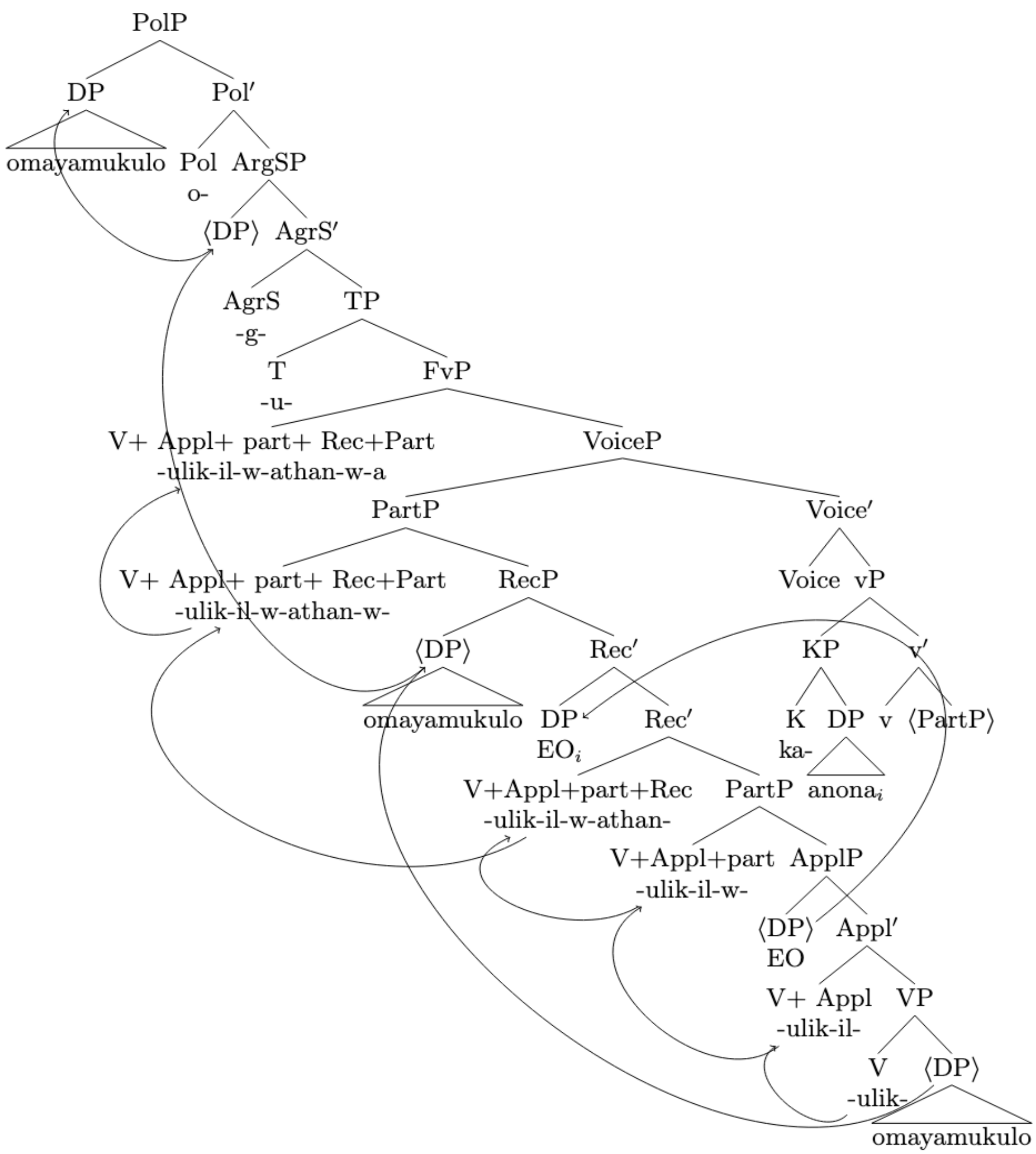
(50) O-ma-yamukulo o-g-u-ulik-il-w-athan-w-a.
AUG-6-answer AFF-6SM-PST-show-APPL-PASS-REC-PASS-FV
'The answers were shown to each other.'



This is a partial structure focusing on the relationship between the implicit argument and the reciprocal argument. To derive the structure in (50), first, the direct object *omayamukulo* leapfrogs over the reciprocal pronoun into an outer Specifier RecP (see section 2). Next, PartP moves to VoiceP and then the DP *omayamukulo* must move to the subject position, Spec,PolP. As shown in the tree, the implicit argument—interpreted as 'the show-er'—c-commands and binds the reciprocal anaphor EO contained in the copy of PartP. This structural configuration satisfies the requirements of Condition A of Binding Theory, and thus, no violation occurs. Note that pro binds into the copy of PartP.

The facts discussed above also holds for *by*-phrase as seen below in (44) provided a full tree. Note that the KP binds the EO contained in the copy of PartP.

(51) O-ma-yamukulo   o-g-u-ulik-il-w-athan-w-a   ka-anona.
AUG-6SM-answer   AFF-6SM-PST-show-APPL-PASS-REC-PASS-FV   by-the children
'The answers were shown to each other by the children.'



5.3 Obligatory Control

Further evidence for the syntactic presence of an implicit external argument comes from obligatory control in Oshiwambo passives, where the implicit argument is interpreted as the controller of PRO in the embedded infinitival clause. Before delving deeper into this phenomenon, it is necessary to first examine obligatory control in Oshiwambo active constructions, as shown below in (52).

(52) a. Penda$_1$ o-kw-a-tokol-a [PRO$_1$ o-ku-tunga e-gumbo.]
1Penda AFF-1SM-PST-decide-FV AUG-15-build 3-house
'Penda decided to build a house.'

b. Penda$_1$ o-kw-a-hal-a [PRO$_1$ o-ku-tunga e-gumbo.]
1Penda AFF-1SM-PST-want-FV AUG-15-build 3-house
'Penda wants to build a house.'

In the sentences above, although the subject of the infinitive *okutunga* is not overtly expressed, it is necessarily understood to be Penda. Penda is therefore said to control the subject of the embedded clause. This control requirement aligns with Landau's (2013) definition of obligatory control**,** which posits a syntactic dependency in which the controller must co-refer with the subject of a nonfinite embedded clause, represented by the null pronoun PRO**.** Now, let us consider obligatory control in Oshiwambo passive constructions.

(53) a. o-sh-a-tokol-w-a [PRO o-ku-tunga e-gumbo.]
AFF-7SM-PST-decide-FV AUG-15-build 3-house
'It was decided to build a house.'

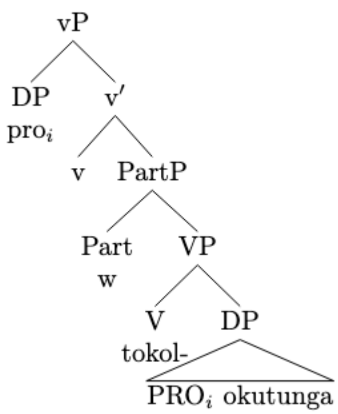
b. [PRO o-ku-tunga e-gumbo] o-kw-a-tokol-w-a.
AFF-15-build 3-house AFF-15SM-PST-decide-FV
'It was decided to build a house.'

(54) a. O-sh-a-halik-w-a [PRO o-ku-tunga e-gumbo.]
AFF-7SM-PST-want-FV AUG-15-build 3-house
'It was wanted to build a house.'

b. [PRO o-ku-tunga e-gumbo] o-kw-a-halik-w-a.
AUG-15-PST-build by-house AFF-15-PST-wanted-PASS-FV
'It was wanted to build a house.'

The sentences above illustrate the control relationship between the implicit argument and *big PRO.* In all of these examples, the implicit argument (*little pro*) controls the subject of the embedded clause (*big PRO*). The *little pro* (implicit argument) and *big PRO* must share the same index. For example, in (53a), the decider must also be the builder, and in (54a), the wanter must be the builder. It should be noted that there is no interpretive difference between the (a) and (b) examples in both (53) and (54). The fact that implicit arguments can participate in control relations supports the claim that the implicit argument in passive constructions remains syntactically active. A partial syntactic tree for an example like (53a) is as follows in (55):

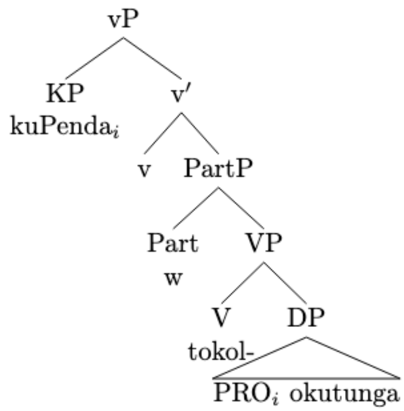
(55) o-sh-a-tokol-w-a [PRO o-ku-tunga e-gumbo.]
AFF-7SM-PST-decide-FV AUG-15-build 3-house
'It was decided to build a house.'



The facts discussed above also holds for the *by*-phrase as seen below in (49). Note that the KP controls PRO.

(56)	o-sh-a-tokol-w-a	ku-Penda	[PRO o-ku-tunga		e-gumbo.]
	AFF-7SM-PST-decide-FV	by-Penda		AUG-15-build	3-house

‘It was decided to build a house by Penda.’



5.4 Condition B effects

Another piece of evidence suggesting the syntactic presence of the external argument comes from Condition B effects, where a pronoun cannot be bound by a local antecedent. Before examining this phenomenon in passive constructions, it is necessary to first consider Condition B effects in active Oshiwambo constructions, as illustrated in (57).

(57) a. O-mu-longi   o-kw-a-tum-in-a   o-ma-yamukulo
AUG-1-teacher   AFF-2SM-PST-send-APPL-FV   aug-6-answer.
kaa-longwa.
LOC17-students
'The teacher sent the answers to the student.'

b. O-mu-longi$_1$ o-kw-a-tum-in-a   o-ma-yamukulo   ku-yo$_{*1/2.}$
AUG-1-teacher   AFF-2SM-PST-send-APPL-FV   aug-6-answer   loc-them
'The teacher sent the students the answers.'

The sentence in (57a) shows a canonical ditransitive applicative construction. Example (57b) demonstrates that the goal argument can be replaced by a pronoun; however, this pronoun cannot co-refer with the subject *omulongi* 'the teacher', because it must be free in its local binding domain. This is the expected Condition B effect**.**

Now consider a context in which a particular teacher secretly provided the students with the answers to an exam, without the grader's knowledge. Later, when the grader marks the exams, she is surprised by how well the students performed. Realizing what must have happened, she turns to a colleague and says:

(58) O-ma-yamukulo   o-ga- a-tum-in-w-a   ku-yo.
AUG-6-answer   AFF-6SM.PST-send-APPL-PASS-FV   Loc-them
'The answers were sent to them.'

In this context, the implicit external argument is necessarily interpreted as the teacher, a discourse-salient and contextually identifiable individual, rather than as an existential agent (cf. Collins 2024: 22). This shows that the implicit argument can receive a definite interpretation (see Collins 2024, chapter 2 for a discussion of the different interpretations of implicit arguments).

Accordingly, sentence (57) is grammatical only if the pronoun *yo* ‘them’ does not corefer with the implicit argument, which is, in this context, necessarily interpreted as ‘the teacher’. Since both the implicit argument and the pronoun occur within the same clause, co-reference would result in a Condition B violation, given that a pronoun may not be locally bound.

Crucially, this interpretation contrasts with a genuinely existential reading, paraphrasable as *‘people sent the answers to them’*, in which no particular individual is identified as the sender. In the context in (57), however, such an existential interpretation is unavailable: the implicit external argument must be understood as the specific teacher introduced in the discourse. In addition, the implicit argument cannot be interpreted as ‘the students’ either, since that would give rise to a Condition B violation.

Additional examples are provided below:

(59) O-o-ngombe   o-dh-a-shing-il-w-a   ku-yo.
AUG-15-skill AFF -10SM-PST-lead-PASS-FV   LOC-them
‘The cows were led to them.’

(60) O-o-mbapila   o-dh-a-nyol-el-w-a   ku-yo.
AUG-10-letter AFF-10SM-PST-write-APPL-PASS-FV   loc-them
‘The letters were written to them.’

These sentences are also acceptable, but only if *yo* ‘them’ does not refer to the implicit argument. Since the sentences in (58-60) are well-formed under this restriction, we may conclude that an implicit argument must be syntactically present. A schematic representation of the configuration that yields the Condition B effect in the passive construction in (58) is shown in (61):

(61) The answers were sent pro_1 to $\text{them}_{*1/2}$.

In (61), the implicit argument pro c-commands the goal argument 'them', consequently, the two cannot be co-indexed, as this would violate Condition B.

Example (62) shows that a reciprocal can be co-referential with the external argument, establishing that co-reference is not categorically prohibited in passive constructions. In this case, the reciprocal EO is co-referential with the implicit external argument (see section 5.2 for a detailed discussion of reciprocals).

(62) o-ma-yamukulo o-ga-tum-in-w-athan-w-a.
AUG-6-answer AFF-6SM-send-APPL-PASS-REC-PASS-FV
'The answers were sent to each other.'

This pattern described in (58-60) above also holds for long passives, as illustrated below:

(63) O-ma-yamukulo o-ga- a-tum-in-w-a ko-mu-longi ku-yo.
AUG-6-answer. AFF-6SM.PST-send-APPL-PASS-FV by-1-teacher Loc-them
'The answers were sent to them by the teacher.'

As in the previous cases, the object pronoun *yo* cannot be co-referential with the postverbal logical subject *komulongi* 'by the teacher', since both elements occur within the same clause. Such co-reference would again result in a Condition B violation, as pronouns cannot be locally bound.

5.5. Depictive secondary predicates

Depictive secondary predicates have often been used in the literature as evidence for diagnosing the presence of implicit arguments in passives. However, as this section will show, depictives do not provide a reliable diagnostic in Oshiwambo due to independent language-specific properties that are shared with other Bantu languages. Unlike English, where depictives typically involve an obligatory control relation—such that the subject of the depictive must be controlled by another argument in the clause (Pylkkänen 2008)—Oshiwambo depictives operate through an anaphoric relation involving a little *pro*. In Oshiwambo, the depictive must have an antecedent with which the little *pro* is coindexed, but this antecedent need not be local, as illustrated in (64). This shows that Oshiwambo depictives do not depend on the same control dependency found in English. Consequently, they cannot reliably indicate the presence of implicit arguments. Given their use in the literature as a diagnostic, I briefly illustrate Oshiwambo depictives.

(64) a. Penda o-kw-a-ly-a o-(n)yama o(m)bishu.

Penda	o-kw-a-ly-a	o-(n)yama	o(m)bishu.
1Penda	AFF-1SM-PST-eat-FV	AUG-9-meat	AUG-9-raw

‘Penda ate the meat raw.’

b.

Penda	o-kw-a-shang-a	o-(m)bapila	a-kolwa.
1Penda	AFF-1SM-PST-write-FV	AUG-9-paper	1-drunk

‘Penda wrote the paper drunk.’

c.

O-y-a-popy-a	na-Ndapewa	a-vulwa.
AFF-2SM-PST-speak-FV	with-1Ndapewa	1-tired.

‘They spoke to Ndapewa tired.’

d.

O-y-a-popy-a	na-Ndapewa	ya-vulwa.
AFF-2SM-PST-speak-FV	with-1Ndapewa	2-tired.

‘They spoke to Ndapewa tired.’

e.

A-a-nona	o-y-a-long-a	ya-vulwa.
AUG-2-child	AFF-2SM-PST-work-FV	2-tired

‘The children worked tired.’

f. A-a-nona   o-y-a-long-a   a-vulwa.
AUG-2-child   AFF-2SM-PST-work-FV   1-tired
'The children worked while he/she was tired.'

In (64a), the depictive *ombishu* 'raw' modifies the object *onyama* 'meat' and therefore agrees with it. Similarly, in (64b), the depictive *akolwa* 'drunk' modifies the subject *Penda* and agrees with it accordingly. (64c) shows that Oshiwambo depictives can also modify DPs within prepositional phrases. In this example, the depictive *avulwa* 'tired' can be construed either with the local antecedent *Ndapewa* or with a non-local antecedent. Thus, (64c) is ambiguous: it may mean that *Ndapewa* was tired, or that someone else was tired at the time when *Ndapewa* was being spoken to. These sentences illustrate that the depictive must obligatorily agree with the DP it modifies. For example, (64e) is grammatical because *tired* agrees with *children*, while (64f) is acceptable only under the interpretation where somebody other than the children is tired —an interpretation that is not available in English. The antecedent requirement ensures that depictives in Oshiwambo align morphologically with their antecedent (as seen in 65), reinforcing the structural distinction between Oshiwambo and languages like English, where control determines the relationship between the depictive and its associated argument. It should be noted that Oshiwambo depictive patterns exactly like in Venda (see Pylkkänen, (2008))

(65) Penda   o-kw-a-ly-a   o-(n)yama$_1$ [pro$_1$ o-(m)bishu].
1Penda   AFF-2SM-PST-eat-FV   AUG-9-meat   AUG-9-raw
'Penda ate the meat raw.'

It should be noted that the depictive *ombishu* in (65) is loosely translated as *it (being) raw*, hence the presence of a little *pro*.

Now let consider the following passive constructions (66). For context let's say you picked up a letter on the ground and upon reading it you realized it is not making any sense and say to your friend:

(66) o-(m)bapila o-y-a-shang-w-a pro_1 [pro_1 a-kolwa.]
AUG-9-paper AFF-9SM-PST-write-PASS-FV 1-drunk
'The letter was written drunk.'

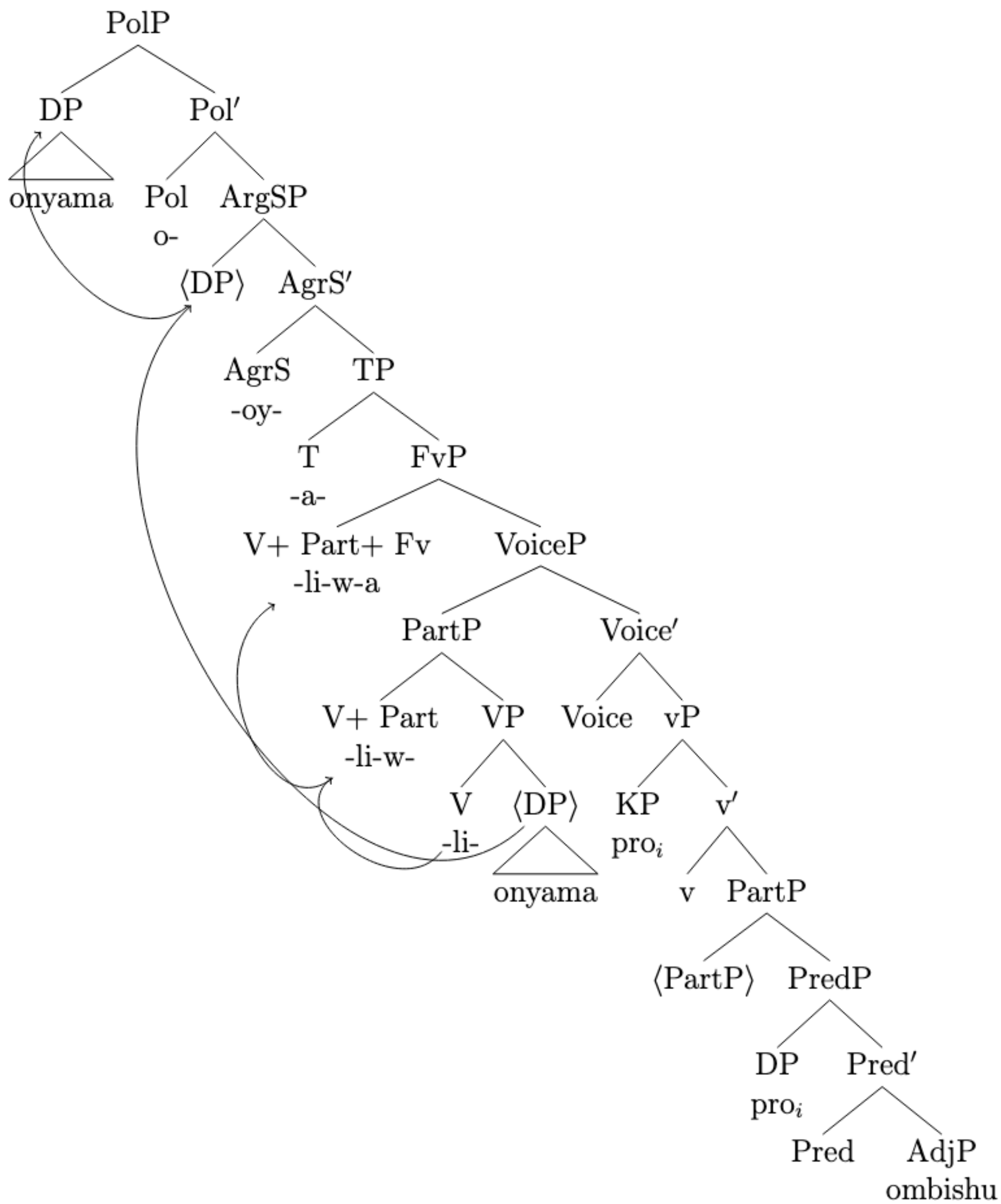
Related examples are as follow

(67) O-m-waaluwa. o-gw-a-long-w-a pro_1 [pro_1 a-vulwa]
AUG-3-math AFF-3SM-PST-teach-PASS-FV 1-tired
'Math was taught tired.'

(68) O-(n)-yama o-y-a-li-w-a pro_1 [pro_1 o(m)bishu].
AUG-9-meat AFF-9SM-eat-PASS-FV aug-9-raw
'The meat was eaten drunk.'

The anaphoric relations in (66–68) show there is an implicit argument binding the depictive. In (66), the depictive suggests that the writer was drunk; in (67), it implies that the teacher was tired; and in (68), it conveys that the eater was tired. However, because a depictive predicate does not need a local anteceded as shown above, we cannot conclude from the facts in (66–68) that the implicit argument syntactically projected. On the assumption that implicit arguments are projected, syntactically, a syntactic tree for an example like (68) would be as follows in (69):

(69) O-(n)-yama o-y-a-li-w-a pro1 [pro1 o-(m)bishu].
AUG-9-meat AFF-9SM-eat-PASS-FV aug-Cl9-raw
'The meat was eaten drunk.'



It should be noted that in all the sentences in (66-68) above it is possible to have a nonlocal antecedent. For example, in (66) it is possible that someone other than the writer was drunk while the book was being written. This interpretation is missing in English. Depictives in Oshiwambo behave differently from their English counterparts and are not subject to the same syntactic constraints. In particular, they are not as tightly constrained with respect to requiring a local antecedent.

6. Two Types of Little pro in Oshiwambo

Oshiwambo exhibits two distinct types of little *pro*: one associated with implicit agents in passive constructions (*passive pro*), and another with subject-drop constructions (*subject-drop pro*). These two types of *pro* differ in both their syntactic behavior and morphological properties. Specifically, *passive pro* surfaces in passive constructions and alternates with an overt *by*-phrase, which explicitly marks the agent. In contrast, *subject-drop pro* alternates with an overt DP subject. Notably, subject-drop *pro* is always definite, with the exception of expletive uses, which I will not be addressing here. For instance, when a sentence like (70) is uttered, the null subject necessarily refers to a specific, contextually identifiable individual. In other words, subject-drop *pro* cannot be interpreted as indefinite or generic; it always picks out a definite referent in the discourse.

(70) O-kw-a-yak-w-a i-i-maliwa.
AFF-17SM-PST-steal-FV AUG-8-money
'She/he stole the money.'

On the other hand, *pro* in passive constructions is not necessarily definite. While in some cases it may be definite, as in the reciprocal examples discussed above, in (71) below the agent is unspecified and does not need to refer to any particular individual. In other words, the interpretive range of passive *pro* is broader than that of subject *pro*. Subject *pro* is always definite and refers to some specific, contextually identifiable individuals, whereas passive *pro* can be either definite or indefinite.

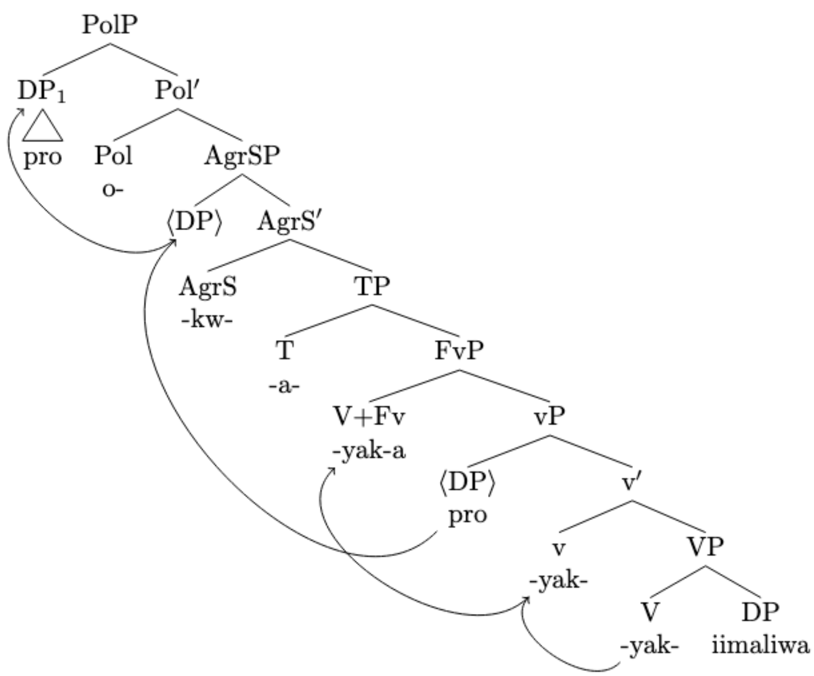
(71) I-i-maliwa o-y-a-yak-w-a.
AUG-CL8-money. AFF-8 SM-PST-steal-PASS-FV
'The money was stolen.'

This contrast also points to a difference in case-marking behavior. *Subject-drop pro* appears to be case-marked, as it alternates with a DP that bears case. By contrast, *passive pro* does not occupy a syntactic position where a case-marked DP can be freely inserted—doing so would violate the case filer.

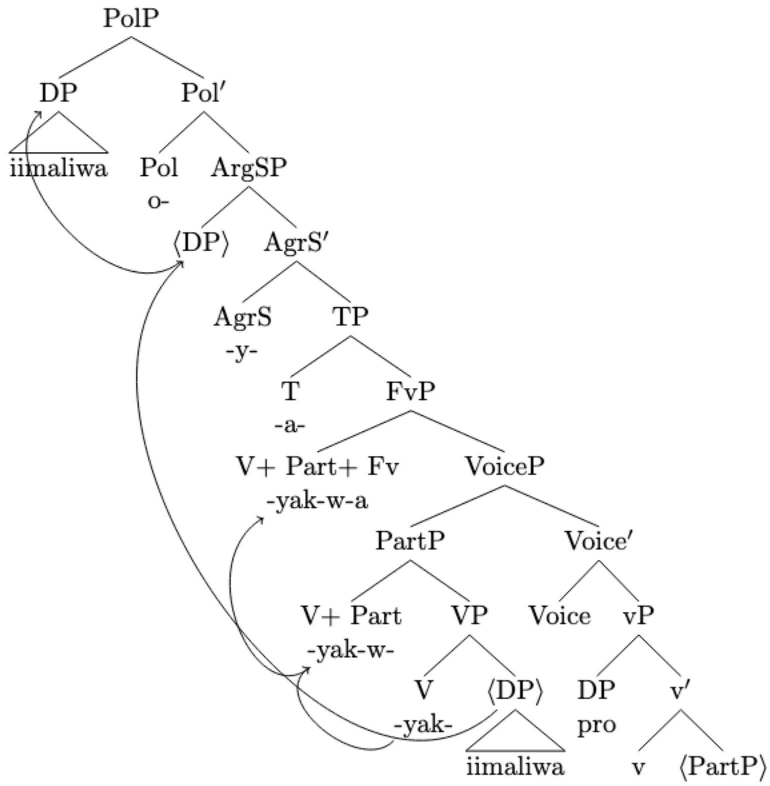
It should be note that the role of Case Theory in Bantu languages remains a topic of ongoing debate. Much of the recent literature has questioned whether abstract Case operates uniformly across languages of this family (see Diercks 2012, Halpert 2011 & 2016, Carstens and Mletshe 2016, Pietraszko 2021 for discussion). I set this broader issue aside for the purposes of this paper.

Consider the partial diagrams in (72) and (73), which illustrate the distinction between the two types of little *pro*.

(72) subject-drop *pro*



(73) passive *pro*



As shown in the structures above, both subject-drop *pro* and passive *pro* are base-generated in Spec-vP. However, subject-drop *pro* raises to the subject position—Spec-PolP—while passive *pro* remains in situ and does not undergo A-movement.

The difference between the two types of little pro is summarized below in Table 3.

Table 3: Differences between Subject pro and Passive pro

Feature	Subject pro	Passive pro
Assigned case	yes	no
Definiteness	yes	sometimes
Alternates with KP	no	yes

6. Conclusion

This paper has examined the syntax of passive constructions in Oshingandjera, a dialect of Oshiwambo, with a particular focus on the status of the implicit external argument. Based on a set of diagnostics—including helke expressions, reciprocal suffix, Condition B effects and obligatory control. I have argued that Oshiwambo passives involve a syntactically projected implicit argument. Specifically, I proposed that this argument is realized as a null pronoun (pro), occupying the external argument position.

The findings presented here contribute to a growing body of cross-linguistic research that challenges traditional views of passive constructions as involving the complete absence of the external argument from syntactic representation. In particular, the results support a framework in which passive voice does not suppress the external argument altogether but instead allows it to be present in a covert form. This perspective is in line with recent proposals by Collins 2024, Gotah 2024, Sulemana 2024 and Angelopoulos, Collins, Michelioudakis, & Terzi 2023 all of whom argue that even when an agent isn't overtly expressed, it can still be structurally present.

This contrasts with Bruening 2013, who argues that the implicit external argument in verbal passives is not syntactically present. His central claim is that the external argument in verbal passives is semantically present but syntactically absent. However, the Oshiwambo data tells a different story. The implicit external argument in Oshingandjera exhibits syntactic behavior that would only be possible if it were part of the derivation. For instance, it is capable of controlling PRO and participates in binding relations. These facts strongly suggest that the implicit argument must be syntactically represented.

Overall, the evidence from Oshiwambo supports the view that the presence of an implicit external argument is not merely a matter of semantic inference but is instead syntactically represented. This finding has important implications for our understanding of argument structure, passive formation, and the cross-linguistic variation in how implicit agents are realized. One avenue for future research, suggested by the present results, concerns the status of impersonal passives in Bantu. Investigating whether these constructions involve a syntactically represented implicit argument, and how they differ from or align with the passive patterns discussed here.

Looking ahead, I hope this work encourages more cross-linguistic investigation into how implicit arguments behave. Understanding whether—and how—they are represented in syntax has the potential to reshape how we think about voice, argument structure, and the architecture of grammar more generally.

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